SPIES IN NEPAL

On 19 September 2008, Nizam Khan was glued to an Indian satellite TV news channel in his money exchange shop at Nabi Plaza in Birat Nagar, Nepal. On the screen, Operation Batla House played out live. Security forces swarmed the street in Jamia Nagar, New Delhi, and a shootout ensued at Batla House between Indian Mujahideen (IM) terrorists and the Delhi police. Two terrorists, Atif Ameen and Mohammed Sajid were killed and two others, Shahzad and Ariz Khan managed to escape.

There has never been such an operation before, Khan thought, and dialed his friend Ayub Sheikh. Their conversation was brief. They decided to meet at the madrassa on Karsiya Road in the evening.

Khan was part of IM's sleeper cell in Nepal and had helped the terror outfit with money, shelter and the passionate conviction that had been indoctrinated in him by Pakistan's InterService Intelligence (ISI) from where he drew his resources as well. His meeting with Ayub primarily discussed the chances of betrayal, which Ayub shrugged off with a smile. Khan, however, decided to keep a low profile for the next couple of weeks. He knew that Operation Batla House had not been a coincidence. Since early 2007 when Indian counterterror agencies launched a massive crackdown against the IM's parent organisation, the Students Islamic Movement of India (SIMI), Khan had been apprehending a sweep. He himself had helped finance several terror-training camps in Kerala where new recruits were provided physical training, arms training, firing practice and lessons in the art of making crude bombs, all to carry out jihad in India.